Void Sovereigns Online — Working Game Doc

1. Core Identity

Title: Void Sovereigns Online
Genre: Browser-first online space opera RPG
Tone: Frontier sci-fi adventure with a slow-burn cosmic horror undercurrent
Aesthetic Mix: NASA-punk utility + 90s anime space-opera styling + ancient alien dread
Primary Visual Touchstones: practical spacecraft and work gear, industrial stations, worn utility hardware, sharp silhouettes, cel-style color blocking, and a cool 90s anime swagger in the spirit of classic bounty-hunter sci-fi

Elevator Pitch:
In a fractured galaxy of relay ruins, drifting stations, pirate belts, and forgotten vaults, players work as freelancers, operatives, scouts, and relic-runners trying to survive among collapsing powers. Beneath ordinary frontier conflict, hints emerge that something ancient is beginning to wake in the dark between systems.

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2. Naming Direction

Naming Rules

- Names should feel readable, sleek, and marketable
- Avoid parody-hard sci-fi jargon
- Avoid direct lifts from Star Wars, Mass Effect, Halo, Destiny, Starfield, or Lovecraft
- Blend institutional names, mythic names, and cold procedural names
- Cosmic horror elements should sound ancient, elegant, and unsettling rather than gooey or campy

Strong Project Name Alternatives

- Void Sovereigns Online
- Sovereigns of the Void
- Void Meridian Online
- Black Relay Online
- Starwake Frontier

- Eclipse Run Online
- Hollow Orbit
- Nightgate Frontier
- Crown of the Dark
- Drift Sovereign

Recommended Final

Void Sovereigns Online

Subtitle / Tagline Ideas

- *The Frontier Hears Them First.*
- *Beyond the Relay, Something Waits.*
- *The Stars Remember.*
- *What Wakes in the Dark Will Rule the Light.*

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3. Setting Foundation

Premise

Generations after the collapse of the relay lattice, the galaxy is fragmented into isolated sectors linked by unstable jump corridors, scavenged gates, and dangerous drift lanes. Small empires, trade leagues, flotillas, militias, and cultic cells compete for territory, relics, and access to ancient infrastructure.

At first, most people believe the old stories about the “Void Sovereigns” are myths, mistranslations, or propaganda. But derelict stations, corrupted black boxes, impossible star maps, and vanished crews suggest something is moving again in deep space.

Early-Game Feel

- frontier work
- station politics
- salvage contracts
- pirate suppression
- ruined facility exploration
- rumors of strange disappearances
- subtle signal anomalies
- mostly contract-focused progression with story threads woven through jobs and faction assignments

Late-Game Feel

- faction war over relic systems
- awakened ruins
- warped sectors
- corrupted fleets
- cosmic incursions
- moral choices around survival vs forbidden power

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4. Factions

4.1 Sol Union Directorate

Role: central lawful remnant state
Identity: disciplined, bureaucratic, heavily regulated, militarized
Style: white, navy, brushed steel, flight insignia
Fantasy: order, stability, command structure
Conflict: losing control of the frontier and hiding how much it really knows

4.2 Frontier Compact

Role: colonies, militias, engineers, settlers
Identity: practical, stubborn, localist, survival-first
Style: industrial orange, matte gray, patched gear
Fantasy: the working frontier, civic grit, jury-rigged survival
Conflict: under-resourced and squeezed between bigger powers

4.3 Vanta Corsairs

Role: smugglers, raiders, privateers, black-market syndicates
Identity: stylish, ruthless, opportunistic
Style: black hull plating, crimson IDs, sleek contraband tech
Fantasy: outlaws, fast ships, high-risk loot
Conflict: thrive on instability but flirt with things they do not understand

4.4 Helion Synod

Role: relic scholars, philosophers, sanctioned mystics
Identity: refined, secretive, ceremonial, obsessed with ancient ruins
Style: ivory, gold, cyan glyph-light
Fantasy: scholar-priests of dead stars
Conflict: divided between cautious study and dangerous communion

4.5 Aegis Division

Role: covert intelligence, black ops, recovery teams
Identity: sealed records, surgical strikes, classified relic programs
Style: graphite, cobalt, low-visibility tactical gear
Fantasy: shadow state operatives
Conflict: knows more about the anomalies than anyone admits

4.6 Glass Choir

Role: subtle cultic network linked to the cosmic threat
Identity: fragmented cells, altered speech, signal obsession, reverent terror
Style: mirrored masks, signal glyphs, ceremonial black and pearl
Fantasy: beautiful and deeply wrong
Conflict: believe awakening the old powers will end history's suffering

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5. Player Races / Peoples

Approach

Use a small launch lineup with strong silhouettes and lore roles. Avoid overdoing "kitchen sink alien zoo." Keep the roster mostly humanoid for animation, gear readability, and a grounded 90s anime ensemble feel.

5.1 Human

Fantasy: adaptable, ambitious, everywhere
Strengths: flexible stat growth, broad faction access
Style: wide cosmetic diversity

5.2 Aurelans

Description: tall, luminous humans descended from long-isolated orbital habitats
Fantasy: elegant void-born specialists
Strengths: navigation, energy systems, diplomacy
Visuals: pale iridescent eyes, lean silhouettes, refined suits

5.3 Bronti

Description: broad-built alien species from high-gravity industrial worlds known for endurance
Fantasy: heavy labor clans, shock troops, station builders

Strengths: armor, recoil control, survivability
Visuals: dense musculature, compact posture, reinforced gear

5.4 Nyxari

Description: quiet alien species adapted to low-light environments with heightened sensory discipline
Fantasy: scouts, infiltrators, relic-divers
Strengths: stealth, perception, precision
Visuals: dark opaline skin tones, reflective eyes, sleek fieldwear

5.5 Veyl

Description: partially bio-synthetic alien species shaped by ancient augmentation traditions
Fantasy: mysterious transhuman relic-kin
Strengths: implant synergy, cooldown reduction, tech affinity
Visuals: elegant integrated filaments, subtle body-tech motifs

5.6 Kharad

Description: nomadic alien fleet culture species with powerful social bonds and martial traditions
Fantasy: wanderers, escorts, duelists, shipborn clans
Strengths: morale, mobility, boarding combat
Visuals: layered fabrics over hard armor, clan insignias

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6. Classes / Archetypes

6.1 Vanguard

Role: frontline assault / tank
Fantasy: shielded spearhead, breach specialist
Weapons: shotcannons, assault rifles, arc blades, heavy sidearms
Core stats: armor, shield, stagger, threat

6.2 Operator

Role: tactical tech / utility / drones
Fantasy: gadgets, battlefield control, sabotage
Weapons: carbines, burst pistols, drones, deployables
Core stats: tech power, cooldown, control, hacking

6.3 Adept

Role: relic/psionic specialist
Fantasy: rare fringe operator who manipulates gravity, phase energy, resonance, and strange relic currents
Weapons: sidearms, beam weapons, focus devices
Core stats: resonance, energy, anomaly resistance, burst power
Setting Note: psionics are fringe, distrusted, poorly understood, and often associated with relic exposure, black programs, or dangerous religious interpretation

6.4 Ranger

Role: precision / mobility / scout
Fantasy: marksman, pathfinder, survival expert
Weapons: marksman rifles, sniper systems, light blades, recon tools
Core stats: crit, evade, detection, movement

6.5 Bounty Hunter

Role: skirmisher / pursuit / burst damage
Fantasy: tracker, contract killer, boarding specialist, elite target hunter
Weapons: SMGs, pistols, scatter weapons, mono-knives
Core stats: speed, crit chain, mark damage, burst mobility

6.6 Warden

Role: support / protector / field commander
Fantasy: anchors squads, buffs allies, stabilizes fights
Weapons: support rifles, shield emitters, medtech tools
Core stats: support power, healing, barriers, squad utility

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7. Starship Classes

Small Craft

- **Skiff** — tiny starter craft, courier/survivor feel
- **Courier** — fast travel, smuggling, recon
- **Interceptor** — combat-light, pursuit focus
- **Shuttle** — utility and passenger transport

Mid-Size Ships

- **Cutter** — balanced all-rounder ship
- **Frigate** — patrol/combat-focused player aspiration ship
- **Salvager** — cargo, drones, extraction tools
- **Surveyor** — scans, anomaly work, exploration bonuses
- **Corsair Hull** — illegal modifications, ambush focus

Large Ships / Endgame Fantasy

- **Cruiser** — faction warship scale
- **Carrier** — drone/fighter support identity
- **Vaultbreaker** — relic assault and excavation platform
- **Cathedral Ship** — Synod ceremonial/relic vessel
- **Black Ark** — horror-linked endgame hostile ship type

Starship Manufacturers / Houses

- Helios Driveworks
- Vanta Lineworks
- Union Fleet Systems
- Carrow Forge
- Meridian Heavy Industries
- Pale Vector Labs

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8. Weapon Types

Kinetic

- sidearm
- heavy sidearm
- SMG
- carbine
- assault rifle
- marksman rifle
- sniper rifle
- shotcannon
- machine gun

Energy

- beam pistol
- beam carbine
- pulse rifle

- arc projector
- plasma caster
- ion lance

Heavy / Exotic

- micro-missile launcher
- rail cannon
- grav hammer
- singularity thrower
- relic emitter
- phase discharger

Melee

- mono-knife
- arc blade
- shock staff
- vibro axe
- phase saber

Support / Utility

- med projector
- shield emitter
- drone command rig
- suppressor field launcher
- decoy beacon

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9. Ammo and Power Types

Conventional Ammo

- light ballistic rounds
- magnum rounds
- flechette shells
- scatter shells
- penetrator rounds
- heavy machine belts

Energy Cells

- standard charge cells
- overcharge cells
- ion cells
- plasma canisters
- arc coils

Heavy Munitions

- micro-rockets
- breacher charges
- grav capsules
- singularity cores
- phase canisters

Special / Rare

- relic shards
- resonance capsules
- null charges
- blacklight cartridges
- echo cores

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10. Add-Ons / Mods / Attachments

Weapon Attachments

- reflex sight
- long scope
- thermal optic
- recoil stabilizer
- magnetic accelerator
- suppressor shroud
- cooling jacket
- expanded magwell
- smart targeting chip
- elemental injector

Armor Add-Ons

- shield booster
- kinetic plating
- thermal weave

- stealth lining
- grav anchor boots
- medfoam dispenser
- sealed void collar
- recoil harness

Ship Add-Ons

- scan array
- cargo expansion grid
- afterburn module
- shield lattice booster
- smuggler bay
- drone rack
- relic containment pod
- interdiction spike
- signal dampener

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11. Implants / Augments

Civilian / Common

- reflex weave
- ocular HUD implant
- subdermal plating
- metabolic regulator
- breath control mesh

Military / Advanced

- tactical co-processor
- recoil nerve bridge
- adrenal trigger implant
- shield sync lattice
- threat analysis node

Relic / Exotic

- resonance spine
- phase gland
- echo receptor
- void-hush cortex mesh

- starwake filament

Risk System Idea

Relic implants can be stronger but may build **Resonance Exposure**, causing:

- whispers in logs
- visual distortion events
- special powers
- faction reactions
- corruption or awakening risks later

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12. Gear Slots

Character Slots

- helmet / hood / visor
- torso armor
- gauntlets
- greaves
- boots
- primary weapon
- secondary weapon
- heavy / utility slot
- relic / focus slot
- implant slots x3
- charm / insignia slot

Ship Slots

- hull
- engine
- reactor
- shield core
- sensor suite
- weapon hardpoints
- utility bay
- cargo bay
- drone bay
- relic containment slot

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13. Enemy Families

Normal Frontier Threats

- pirates
- corsair raiders
- scav gangs
- rogue militia
- rogue security drones
- void fauna
- contract mercenaries

Mid-Tier Strange Threats

- signal-burned crews
- relic-touched marauders
- hollow drones
- ash pilgrims
- glass cult cells
- phase-spliced beasts

Late Horror Threats

- drowned heralds
- sovereign shards
- cathedral things
- black choir vessels
- null-born leviathans

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14. Zone / Sector Naming Ideas

Hub Names

- Meridian Station
- Crownlight Port
- Hollow Reach
- Driftgate Exchange
- Bastion Ring
- Carrow Spindle

Sector Names

- Ashwake Belt
- Orison Verge
- Cinder Span
- The Hush Expanse
- Nadir Reach
- Vale Meridian
- Glass Orbit
- Black Cauter Sector

Dungeon / Instance Names

- derelict frigate
- sealed observatory
- abandoned relay core
- excavation vault
- cryo ark
- blacksite foundry
- signal shrine
- broken cathedral ship

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15. Starter Hub — Meridian Station

Core Concept

Meridian Station is the starter hub and primary early-game social/economic center of Void Sovereigns Online. It is a massive converted mining outpost that once served as the premier trade and transit station for its region of space. Decades ago, Meridian thrived because it sat near reliable Void Relays and was a critical transfer point for freight, passengers, survey teams, military contracts, and deep-sector expeditions.

That era is over.

A series of relay failures and route collapses gradually cut Meridian off from the most profitable corridors. What was once a gleaming regional gateway has become a worn-down frontier outpost full of budget traffic, stranded workers, scavengers, drifters, smugglers, debt-runners, contract crews, and people who cannot afford to leave. It is still enormous, still important, and still busy — but now it feels tired, patched over, and one bad year away from slipping even further.

Station Fantasy

- old prestige, current decline

- blue-collar frontier life
- massive industrial bones beneath commercial retrofits
- practical NASA-punk machinery with stylish 90s anime character energy
- low-rent survival layered over the remains of former grandeur
- a place where fortunes can still start, even if empires no longer care

Why Players Start Here

Meridian is ideal as a starting hub because it gives players:

- access to basic jobs and contracts
- a believable mix of legal and illegal opportunity
- cheap docks, cheap rooms, and cheap work
- many factions operating in the same overcrowded place
- constant traffic from damaged routes, stranded crews, and salvage operations
- a natural place for rumors, relics, black markets, and missing-person jobs

Early-Game Core Goal: the player starts with access to a low-end ship that is good enough for local contracts, short-range travel, and survival work around Meridian, but not good enough to safely reach an active Void Relay. The first major progression objective is to earn enough credits, salvage, parts, licenses, and reputation to acquire a better ship capable of making the trip to a functioning relay and opening the wider game world.

Why Meridian Declined

The station's fall came slowly rather than through one disaster.

Key causes:

- several nearby **Void Relays** became unstable, unreliable, or dead
- major shipping lanes rerouted elsewhere
- better-funded hub stations rose closer to intact relay chains
- military and corporate investment dried up
- infrastructure aged faster than it could be fully replaced
- Meridian became a place people used when they had to, not when they had options

Present-Day Identity

Meridian is now:

- a low-rent trade station
- a salvage and contract economy hub
- a choke point for damaged-route traffic
- a haven for freelancers, bounty hunters, haulers, and relic-runners
- a place where respectable institutions and desperate people share the same corridors

It still has prestige in its bones. You can see it in the old concourse architecture, the overbuilt docking ring, the grand transit halls, and the faded insignias from its golden era. But much of that glory is now hidden beneath repair plating, neon patchwork signage, subdivided cargo decks, and improvised housing.

Visual Identity

- gigantic rotating industrial structure built around an old mining spindle
- ore-processing rings converted into docks, markets, machine decks, and hab blocks
- worn utility lighting, hazard striping, repair scaffolds, cargo cranes, exposed conduit
- remnants of old luxury transit architecture mixed with blue-collar grime
- bustling low-rent food stalls, contract boards, used parts kiosks, shrine corners, crew bars, and faction booths
- overall presentation: practical station hardware, but animated with stylish 90s anime silhouettes, coats, jumpsuits, visors, and ship-crew swagger

Districts

The Spine

The oldest central structural column of the station, once built for ore transfer and heavy processing. Now it is packed with machine access, maintenance routes, lift systems, repair tunnels, and old sealed sections.

Gameplay role: industrial jobs, engineering contacts, maintenance missions, hidden routes

Crown Concourse

The old prestige commercial ring. Once elegant, now half-faded but still functioning as the station's most visible public face.

Gameplay role: markets, faction kiosks, civilian shops, transit terminals, starter social hub

Dock Nine Belt

A rough docking district used by independent haulers, salvage crews, and contract ships. Loud, dangerous, busy, and full of opportunity.

Gameplay role: ship services, cargo jobs, smuggling hooks, bounty postings, black-market contacts

The Shallows

Low-rent residential and spillover commercial decks formed from repurposed worker housing, abandoned support corridors, and subdivided hab modules.

Gameplay role: starter housing flavor, local side quests, gang trouble, missing persons, everyday station life

Ash Market

A gray-market bazaar where scavenged goods, questionable relic fragments, hacked components, and expired military stock quietly circulate.

Gameplay role: rare item hooks, illegal jobs, rumor gathering, risky upgrades

Relay Chapel

A district built around an old relay-monitoring and memorial complex. Officially it is part shrine, part signal archive, part civic remembrance space.

Gameplay role: lore, memorial quests, signal anomaly rumors, early subtle cosmic-horror foreshadowing

Core Services

Meridian should contain the player's early core loop services:

- contract board
- ship dock and refuel/resupply services
- fabrication shop
- medbay
- low-tier market vendors
- ship part broker
- bounty registry terminal
- storage and freight locker
- faction liaison kiosks
- bar / crew canteen / rumor hub

Story Function

Meridian Station should anchor the early game as a place where the player is just another working spacer trying to stay solvent. The station teaches the contract loop, introduces factions, establishes ship ownership as central progression, and slowly exposes the player to odd reports connected to the broken relay network.

The player's practical dream in the early game is simple: stop living contract to contract in a barely reliable local craft and earn a ship good enough to break out of Meridian's shrinking orbit. Reaching a functioning Void Relay should feel like the first true threshold moment of the game.

The cosmic threat should first be felt here through:

- strange relay static
- archived distress logs
- rumors of crews vanishing on short routes
- station workers speaking about sealed decks and signal dead zones
- relic fragments circulating through Ash Market
- memorial walls with too many recent names

Tone Keywords

- faded grandeur
- practical survival
- crowded loneliness
- blue-collar sci-fi
- station romance
- rust and neon
- industrial melancholy
- frontier opportunity

Recommended Supporting NPC Types

- exhausted dockmaster
- cheerful junk dealer
- contract dispatcher with military past
- medtech who patches up freelancers for cash
- old relay archivist
- suspicious Synod observer
- Aegis liaison pretending to be unimportant
- bartender who always hears things first
- ship mechanic who can keep anything flying

Starter Hub Summary

Meridian Station is a giant former premier trade and mining outpost now living on damaged-route traffic, salvage, and desperation. It is big enough to feel legendary, worn enough to feel believable, and crowded enough to support contracts, factions, markets, ship progression, and mystery from the very start.

16. Currency and Resource Ideas

Currencies

- Credits
- Fleet Marks
- Synod Seals

- Black Market Scrip
- Relic Tokens

Crafting / Upgrade Resources

- salvage alloy
- polymer weave
- reactor dust
- charge gel
- medfoam compounds
- quantum seals
- relic glass
- null residue
- signal ash

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16. Folder Structure for the New Project

```
void-sovereigns-online/
  docs/
    game-bible/
      world-overview.md
      style-guide.md
      terminology.md
      factions.md
      classes.md
      races.md
      starships.md
      weapons.md
      implants.md
      enemies.md
      sectors.md
      progression.md
    roadmap/
      milestone-01-vertical-slice.md
      milestone-02-content-pipeline.md
      milestone-03-multiplayer.md
  client/
    public/
    src/
      app/
        routes/
        layout/
```

```
      store/
    game/
      scenes/
      systems/
      entities/
      combat/
      ui/
      assets/
      data/
        factions/
        classes/
        races/
        weapons/
        ammo/
        items/
        implants/
        ships/
        enemies/
        sectors/
        lore/
        quests/
    shared/
      types/
      constants/
      utils/
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  src/
    config/
    auth/
    rooms/
    world/
    combat/
    inventory/
    progression/
    economy/
    chat/
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    events/
    persistence/
    scripts/
shared/
  schema/
  types/
  constants/
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content/
  json/
    factions/
    classes/
    races/
    weapons/
    ammo/
    items/
    implants/
    ships/
    enemies/
    sectors/
    lore/
    quests/
    events/
  localization/
tools/
  content-validation/
  generators/
  migration/
art/
  logos/
  ui/
  concept/
  icons/
audio/
  music/
  sfx/
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17. Strong First-Pass Final Picks

Recommended Launch Hub

Meridian Station

Recommended Starter Sector Names

- Ashwake Belt
- Orison Verge
- Nadir Reach

Recommended Launch Races

- Human
- Aurelans
- Bronti
- Nyxari
- Veyl

Recommended Launch Classes

- Vanguard
- Operator
- Adept
- Ranger
- Bounty Hunter
- Warden

Recommended Tone Keywords

- lonely
- elegant
- frontier
- dangerous
- stylish
- practical
- beautiful
- ancient
- restrained
- uncanny

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18. Direction Locked for Next Pass

- **Overall setting:** NASA-punk practical in-world, with a stylish 90s anime presentation
- **Species design:** mostly humanoid silhouettes
- **Ship ownership:** central progression pillar
- **Psionics/relic powers:** fringe, distrusted, and uncommon
- **Early game structure:** mostly contract-focused, with story woven into jobs, factions, and discoveries

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19. Starter Sector — Ashwake Belt

Core Concept

Ashwake Belt is the starter sector directly connected to Meridian Station. It consists of old mining asteroids, cracked extraction platforms, abandoned ore-transfer rigs, tethered worker habitats, and half-functional industrial nodes scattered through a dusty debris field. Once, the belt fed Meridian's rise. Now it survives as a low-profit salvage zone, contract site, and danger pocket for beginner crews.

Ashwake is close enough to Meridian for routine traffic, cheap jobs, and emergency returns, which makes it the natural first sector for new players. It introduces the game's core loop: fly out from the station, take contracts, clear threats, salvage materials, and return with enough profit to keep your ship running.

Sector Fantasy

- nearby but hazardous frontier work
- worn industrial asteroid infrastructure
- dead extraction lines and drifting machinery
- beginner salvage and combat jobs
- proof that Meridian's past wealth came from real labor and real extraction
- first hints that some old mining sites shut down for reasons beyond ordinary bankruptcy

Visual Identity

- dark rock bodies laced with old mining cuts and floodlights
- rusted gantries and mag-rail trusses spanning asteroid surfaces
- drifting cargo containers and severed tether lines
- rotating processing rigs with partial power
- faded corporate logos from Meridian's golden age
- damaged maintenance drones moving through dust clouds and spark-lit corridors

Why It Matters

Ashwake Belt teaches players:

- ship launch and return loop
- contract acceptance and completion
- early combat against mechanical enemies
- salvage and crafting resource collection
- dungeon/instance exploration in a practical sci-fi context
- how the frontier survives on the bones of old industry
- how local work feeds into the larger goal of upgrading to a relay-capable ship

Main Threats

- rogue mining robots
- damaged loader frames
- corrupted drilling drones
- defensive turret clusters
- desperate scav crews
- unstable reactor or vent hazards

Why the Robots Went Rogue

Publicly, the answer is simple: deferred maintenance, old automation systems, corrupted firmware, and abandoned sites left running too long.

Unofficially, some black-box logs and sealed maintenance reports hint that a few shutdown incidents involved:

- sensor ghosts
- command loops from dead signal relays
- units following non-human pattern instructions
- miners reporting strange audio from deep shafts before disappearing

These details should stay subtle early on.

Early Dungeons / Instances

1. Shalehook Dig Site

A stripped-down asteroid mine with unstable loader tunnels, broken conveyors, and hostile extraction drones.

Purpose: first simple dungeon
Threats: cutter drones, loader bots, turret nodes
Rewards: salvage alloy, charge gel, low-tier ship parts, basic weapon mods

2. Cinder Jack Processing Node

A half-powered ore refinery platform where automated defense systems still treat all intruders as trespassers.

Purpose: first harder dungeon
Threats: sentry bots, mag-clamp walkers, refinery hazards
Rewards: polymer weave, reactor dust, fabrication parts, uncommon components

3. Lantern Vein Access Shaft

A sealed and partially collapsed drilling facility dug deeper than station records comfortably explain.

Purpose: early mystery dungeon
Threats: rogue mining frames, environmental hazards, strange sensor interference
Rewards: relic-touched scrap, unusual logs, anomaly foreshadowing, rare crafting resources

Sector Subzones

- **Outer Cut:** easy asteroid work sites and salvage paths
- **Breaker Yard:** damaged processing rigs and scrapyard combat spaces
- **Tether Grave:** drifting work platforms and cut hab sections
- **Lantern Vein Cluster:** deeper, more dangerous mining sites with mystery hooks

Rewards and Resources

Primary early resources found here:

- salvage alloy
- polymer weave
- reactor dust
- charge gel
- damaged servos
- mining optics
- hull sealant foam
- broken AI cores

Story Function

Ashwake Belt establishes the ordinary frontier reality of the game. It shows that work is dangerous, equipment is old, and every faction is trying to squeeze profit out of failing infrastructure. It also quietly plants the first layer of mystery through corrupted maintenance logs, vanished miners, and a few machine behaviors that do not fully fit normal malfunction patterns.

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20. Meridian Station — Early NPC Roster

20.1 Tamsin Vale — Contract Dispatcher

Former logistics officer who now manages a large share of low-tier freelance jobs around Meridian.

Role: first major mission giver
Personality: brisk, competent, dry humor, permanently overworked
Function: introduces contracts, teaches players how to build reputation, points them toward Ashwake Belt

20.2 Rook Mendera — Dockmaster of Dock Nine Belt

A hard-edged veteran who knows every kind of pilot, scam, and cargo trick in the district.

Role: ship launch/dock services, local warnings
Personality: skeptical, sharp, secretly protective of new crews who listen
Function: teaches ship procedures, docking, fuel/resupply, basic survival advice

20.3 Ilya Sorn — Ship Mechanic

Keeps starter ships alive with salvaged parts, profanity, and miracles.

Role: repair, upgrade introduction, basic ship progression
Personality: blunt, funny, grease-stained genius
Function: early ship upgrades, repair tutorials, introduces junker-to-keeper progression

20.4 Nera Quill — Ash Market Parts Broker

Dealer in scavenged components, questionable mods, and things that "fell off a freighter."

Role: gray-market vendor
Personality: charming, opportunistic, always three steps ahead
Function: early black-market gear, risky upgrades, rumor hooks, scavenger contacts

20.5 Brother Caldus — Relay Chapel Archivist

Caretaker of old relay memorials, signal logs, and the station’s forgotten names.

Role: lore and memorial quest giver
Personality: gentle, unnervingly observant, speaks like history is alive
Function: introduces old relay lore, missing crews, and the first subtle anomaly threads

20.6 Dr. Sena Marr — Freelance Medtech

Patches up anyone who can pay and a few who cannot.

Role: healing, consumables, field survival guidance
Personality: practical, compassionate, tired of preventable stupidity
Function: med items, healing loop, recovery after dangerous contracts

20.7 Vey Oris — Bounty Registry Liaison

Officially tracks wanted targets, fugitive crews, and local enforcement contracts.

Role: bounty mission giver
Personality: polished, detached, quietly ruthless
Function: introduces target-hunt jobs, criminal factions, and higher-risk combat work

20.8 Lio Vent — Crew Bar Owner

Runs a station bar that doubles as an informal information exchange for freelancers.

Role: rumor hub
Personality: warm until crossed, impossible to surprise
Function: side quests, local gossip, hidden job leads, social worldbuilding

20.9 Agent Serik Dane — Aegis Observer

Official cover identity: "transit risk analyst." Actual role: clearly more than that.

Role: shadowy mid-early quest contact
Personality: controlled, precise, unreadable
Function: introduces classified salvage recoveries, sealed decks, and suspicious relay investigations

20.10 Asha Renn — Frontier Compact Quartermaster

Coordinates supplies and defense aid for struggling local crews and colony traffic.

Role: practical faction representative
Personality: grounded, no-nonsense, community-minded
Function: introduces civic-defense jobs, supply runs, militia support, and local reputation building

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21. Early Contract Categories

21.1 Scrap Recovery

Retrieve usable parts, broken robotics, processed ore stock, or lost cargo from old work sites.

Gameplay focus: exploration, light combat, salvage economy
Typical location: Ashwake Belt dig sites and processing platforms

21.2 Robot Suppression

Clear rogue mining robots, defensive drones, or malfunctioning security units from abandoned or semi-active facilities.

Gameplay focus: core early combat loop
Typical location: mines, refineries, old maintenance corridors

21.3 Equipment Retrieval

Recover a damaged toolkit, black box, power regulator, ship part, or relay component from a hostile site.

Gameplay focus: objective-based dungeon runs
Typical location: derelicts and sealed industrial nodes

21.4 Survey and Scan Jobs

Map asteroid pockets, verify signal disturbances, inspect relays, or scan unstable industrial zones.

Gameplay focus: travel, exploration, subtle mystery introduction
Typical location: outer debris routes, relay-monitoring sites, sealed shafts

21.5 Bounty Contracts

Track fugitives, deserters, scavenger leaders, smugglers, or station-wanted raiders.

Gameplay focus: target hunting, combat escalation, criminal worldbuilding
Typical location: dock districts, belt hideouts, wreck clusters

21.6 Escort and Freight Runs

Accompany a hauler, protect a shuttle, move scarce supplies, or deliver time-sensitive components.

Gameplay focus: route risk, defense, station-to-sector loop
Typical location: Meridian to nearby sector lanes

21.7 Missing Crew Investigations

Search for miners, surveyors, repair teams, or independent pilots who failed to return.

Gameplay focus: mystery, environmental storytelling, higher narrative weight
Typical location: deep belt work sites, collapsed access shafts, old hab modules

21.8 Station Trouble Jobs

Handle gang problems, repair failures, thefts, local disputes, and civic maintenance issues inside Meridian.

Gameplay focus: hub life, side quests, low-travel variety
Typical location: The Shallows, Dock Nine Belt, Crown Concourse

Contract Structure Philosophy

Early contracts should feel like real frontier work first:

- practical
- dangerous
- underpaid
- immediate

But they should all also feed the first major player ambition:

- earn enough to stop renting survival
- improve or replace the starter ship
- secure better components
- qualify for longer-range work
- eventually reach an active Void Relay

Layered beneath that should be a gradually growing pattern:

- too many broken logs
- too many vanished workers
- too many machine systems acting strangely near damaged relays
- too many people insisting it is all coincidence

Recommended Early Contract Mix

The opening hours should emphasize:

- Scrap Recovery
- Robot Suppression
- Equipment Retrieval
- a few Station Trouble Jobs
- one or two Missing Crew Investigations with quiet anomaly undertones

---

22. Early Core Progression Goal

The First Big Dream

The early game should revolve around one clear practical objective:

Buy, win, rebuild, or otherwise secure a better ship that can safely reach a functioning Void Relay.

This goal gives structure to the contract loop and makes progression feel grounded. The player is not chasing abstract destiny at first — they are trying to escape the trap of local-only survival and earn passage into the wider frontier.

Starting Ship Situation

The player begins with a ship that is:

- old
- cheap
- barely spaceworthy
- good enough for local sector work
- not trusted for deep-route relay travel

Possible starter ship framing:

- inherited wreck
- debt-anchored lease ship
- repo-surplus contractor skiff
- ex-industrial utility craft patched for civilian use

What the Better Ship Represents

A relay-capable ship means:

- freedom of movement
- access to better-paying sectors
- access to larger faction work
- a real stake in the wider galaxy
- the beginning of the game's next chapter

What the Player Needs to Get There

To reach this milestone, the player may need a combination of:

- credits
- salvage materials
- upgraded drive components

- a route permit or relay clearance
- faction reputation
- black-market parts or legal certification

Narrative Importance

This objective should define the emotional arc of the early game:

- at first, the player is trapped in Meridian's local economy
- then they learn how the station survives on scraps and failing routes
- then they build enough resources and trust to attempt something bigger
- finally, reaching the Void Relay becomes the first major transition from local drifter to true frontier operator

Design Value

This goal works because it ties together:

- ship progression
- contracts
- economy
- faction reputation
- exploration
- story escalation

It is concrete, understandable, and motivating.

23. Suggested Next Docs

Next, build these in order:

1. `WORLD_OVERVIEW.md`
2. `FACTIONS.md`
3. `STARTER_SECTOR.md`
4. `EARLY_GAME_LOOP.md`
5. `STARSHIP_PROGRESSION.md`
6. `CLASSES.md`
7. `RACES.md`
8. `WEAPONS_AND_IMPLANTS.md`

Void Sovereigns Online — Working Game Doc

1. Core Identity

Title: Void Sovereigns Online
Genre: Browser-first online space opera RPG
Tone: Frontier sci-fi adventure with a slow-burn cosmic horror undercurrent
Aesthetic Mix: NASA-punk utility + 90s anime space-opera styling + ancient alien dread
Primary Visual Touchstones: practical spacecraft and work gear, industrial stations, worn utility hardware, sharp silhouettes, cel-style color blocking, and a cool 90s anime swagger in the spirit of classic bounty-hunter sci-fi

Elevator Pitch:
In a fractured galaxy of relay ruins, drifting stations, pirate belts, and forgotten vaults, players work as freelancers, operatives, scouts, and relic-runners trying to survive among collapsing powers. Beneath ordinary frontier conflict, hints emerge that something ancient is beginning to wake in the dark between systems.

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2. Naming Direction

Naming Rules

- Names should feel readable, sleek, and marketable
- Avoid parody-hard sci-fi jargon
- Avoid direct lifts from Star Wars, Mass Effect, Halo, Destiny, Starfield, or Lovecraft
- Blend institutional names, mythic names, and cold procedural names
- Cosmic horror elements should sound ancient, elegant, and unsettling rather than gooey or campy

Strong Project Name Alternatives

- Void Sovereigns Online
- Sovereigns of the Void
- Void Meridian Online
- Black Relay Online
- Starwake Frontier
- Eclipse Run Online
- Hollow Orbit

- Nightgate Frontier
- Crown of the Dark
- Drift Sovereign

Recommended Final

Void Sovereigns Online

Subtitle / Tagline Ideas

- *The Frontier Hears Them First.*
- *Beyond the Relay, Something Waits.*
- *The Stars Remember.*
- *What Wakes in the Dark Will Rule the Light.*

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3. Setting Foundation

Premise

Generations after the collapse of the relay lattice, the galaxy is fragmented into isolated sectors linked by unstable jump corridors, scavenged gates, and dangerous drift lanes. Small empires, trade leagues, flotillas, militias, and cultic cells compete for territory, relics, and access to ancient infrastructure.

At first, most people believe the old stories about the “Void Sovereigns” are myths, mistranslations, or propaganda. But derelict stations, corrupted black boxes, impossible star maps, and vanished crews suggest something is moving again in deep space.

Early-Game Feel

- frontier work
- station politics
- salvage contracts
- pirate suppression
- ruined facility exploration
- rumors of strange disappearances
- subtle signal anomalies
- mostly contract-focused progression with story threads woven through jobs and faction assignments

Late-Game Feel

- faction war over relic systems
- awakened ruins
- warped sectors
- corrupted fleets
- cosmic incursions
- moral choices around survival vs forbidden power

---

4. Factions

4.1 Sol Union Directorate

Role: central lawful remnant state
Identity: disciplined, bureaucratic, heavily regulated, militarized
Style: white, navy, brushed steel, flight insignia
Fantasy: order, stability, command structure
Conflict: losing control of the frontier and hiding how much it really knows

4.2 Frontier Compact

Role: colonies, militias, engineers, settlers
Identity: practical, stubborn, localist, survival-first
Style: industrial orange, matte gray, patched gear
Fantasy: the working frontier, civic grit, jury-rigged survival
Conflict: under-resourced and squeezed between bigger powers

4.3 Vanta Corsairs

Role: smugglers, raiders, privateers, black-market syndicates
Identity: stylish, ruthless, opportunistic
Style: black hull plating, crimson IDs, sleek contraband tech
Fantasy: outlaws, fast ships, high-risk loot
Conflict: thrive on instability but flirt with things they do not understand

4.4 Helion Synod

Role: relic scholars, philosophers, sanctioned mystics
Identity: refined, secretive, ceremonial, obsessed with ancient ruins
Style: ivory, gold, cyan glyph-light
Fantasy: scholar-priests of dead stars
Conflict: divided between cautious study and dangerous communion

4.5 Aegis Division

Role: covert intelligence, black ops, recovery teams
Identity: sealed records, surgical strikes, classified relic programs
Style: graphite, cobalt, low-visibility tactical gear
Fantasy: shadow state operatives
Conflict: knows more about the anomalies than anyone admits

4.6 Glass Choir

Role: subtle cultic network linked to the cosmic threat
Identity: fragmented cells, altered speech, signal obsession, reverent terror
Style: mirrored masks, signal glyphs, ceremonial black and pearl
Fantasy: beautiful and deeply wrong
Conflict: believe awakening the old powers will end history's suffering

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5. Player Races / Peoples

Approach

Use a small launch lineup with strong silhouettes and lore roles. Avoid overdoing "kitchen sink alien zoo." Keep the roster mostly humanoid for animation, gear readability, and a grounded 90s anime ensemble feel.

5.1 Human

Fantasy: adaptable, ambitious, everywhere
Strengths: flexible stat growth, broad faction access
Style: wide cosmetic diversity

5.2 Aurelans

Description: tall, luminous humans descended from long-isolated orbital habitats
Fantasy: elegant void-born specialists
Strengths: navigation, energy systems, diplomacy
Visuals: pale iridescent eyes, lean silhouettes, refined suits

5.3 Bronti

Description: broad-built alien species from high-gravity industrial worlds known for endurance
Fantasy: heavy labor clans, shock troops, station builders
Strengths: armor, recoil control, survivability
Visuals: dense musculature, compact posture, reinforced gear

5.4 Nyxari

Description: quiet alien species adapted to low-light environments with heightened sensory discipline
Fantasy: scouts, infiltrators, relic-divers
Strengths: stealth, perception, precision
Visuals: dark opaline skin tones, reflective eyes, sleek fieldwear

5.5 Veyl

Description: partially bio-synthetic alien species shaped by ancient augmentation traditions
Fantasy: mysterious transhuman relic-kin
Strengths: implant synergy, cooldown reduction, tech affinity
Visuals: elegant integrated filaments, subtle body-tech motifs

5.6 Kharad

Description: nomadic alien fleet culture species with powerful social bonds and martial traditions
Fantasy: wanderers, escorts, duelists, shipborn clans
Strengths: morale, mobility, boarding combat
Visuals: layered fabrics over hard armor, clan insignias

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6. Classes / Archetypes

6.1 Vanguard

Role: frontline assault / tank
Fantasy: shielded spearhead, breach specialist
Weapons: shotcannons, assault rifles, arc blades, heavy sidearms
Core stats: armor, shield, stagger, threat

6.2 Operator

Role: tactical tech / utility / drones
Fantasy: gadgets, battlefield control, sabotage
Weapons: carbines, burst pistols, drones, deployables
Core stats: tech power, cooldown, control, hacking

6.3 Adept

Role: relic/psionic specialist
Fantasy: rare fringe operator who manipulates gravity, phase energy, resonance, and strange relic currents
Weapons: sidearms, beam weapons, focus devices
Core stats: resonance, energy, anomaly resistance, burst power
Setting Note: psionics are fringe, distrusted, poorly understood, and often associated with relic exposure, black programs, or dangerous religious interpretation

6.4 Ranger

Role: precision / mobility / scout
Fantasy: marksman, pathfinder, survival expert
Weapons: marksman rifles, sniper systems, light blades, recon tools
Core stats: crit, evade, detection, movement

6.5 Bounty Hunter

Role: skirmisher / pursuit / burst damage
Fantasy: tracker, contract killer, boarding specialist, elite target hunter
Weapons: SMGs, pistols, scatter weapons, mono-knives
Core stats: speed, crit chain, mark damage, burst mobility

6.6 Warden

Role: support / protector / field commander
Fantasy: anchors squads, buffs allies, stabilizes fights
Weapons: support rifles, shield emitters, medtech tools
Core stats: support power, healing, barriers, squad utility

---

7. Starship Classes

Small Craft

- **Skiff** — tiny starter craft, courier/survivor feel
- **Courier** — fast travel, smuggling, recon
- **Interceptor** — combat-light, pursuit focus
- **Shuttle** — utility and passenger transport

Mid-Size Ships

- **Cutter** — balanced all-rounder ship
- **Frigate** — patrol/combat-focused player aspiration ship

- **Salvager** — cargo, drones, extraction tools
- **Surveyor** — scans, anomaly work, exploration bonuses
- **Corsair Hull** — illegal modifications, ambush focus

Large Ships / Endgame Fantasy

- **Cruiser** — faction warship scale
- **Carrier** — drone/fighter support identity
- **Vaultbreaker** — relic assault and excavation platform
- **Cathedral Ship** — Synod ceremonial/relic vessel
- **Black Ark** — horror-linked endgame hostile ship type

Starship Manufacturers / Houses

- Helios Driveworks
- Vanta Lineworks
- Union Fleet Systems
- Carrow Forge
- Meridian Heavy Industries
- Pale Vector Labs

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8. Weapon Types

Kinetic

- sidearm
- heavy sidearm
- SMG
- carbine
- assault rifle
- marksman rifle
- sniper rifle
- shotcannon
- machine gun

Energy

- beam pistol
- beam carbine
- pulse rifle
- arc projector
- plasma caster

- ion lance

Heavy / Exotic

- micro-missile launcher
- rail cannon
- grav hammer
- singularity thrower
- relic emitter
- phase discharger

Melee

- mono-knife
- arc blade
- shock staff
- vibro axe
- phase saber

Support / Utility

- med projector
- shield emitter
- drone command rig
- suppressor field launcher
- decoy beacon

---

9. Ammo and Power Types

Conventional Ammo

- light ballistic rounds
- magnum rounds
- flechette shells
- scatter shells
- penetrator rounds
- heavy machine belts

Energy Cells

- standard charge cells
- overcharge cells

- ion cells
- plasma canisters
- arc coils

Heavy Munitions

- micro-rockets
- breacher charges
- grav capsules
- singularity cores
- phase canisters

Special / Rare

- relic shards
- resonance capsules
- null charges
- blacklight cartridges
- echo cores

---

10. Add-Ons / Mods / Attachments

Weapon Attachments

- reflex sight
- long scope
- thermal optic
- recoil stabilizer
- magnetic accelerator
- suppressor shroud
- cooling jacket
- expanded magwell
- smart targeting chip
- elemental injector

Armor Add-Ons

- shield booster
- kinetic plating
- thermal weave
- stealth lining
- grav anchor boots

- medfoam dispenser
- sealed void collar
- recoil harness

Ship Add-Ons

- scan array
- cargo expansion grid
- afterburn module
- shield lattice booster
- smuggler bay
- drone rack
- relic containment pod
- interdiction spike
- signal dampener

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11. Implants / Augments

Civilian / Common

- reflex weave
- ocular HUD implant
- subdermal plating
- metabolic regulator
- breath control mesh

Military / Advanced

- tactical co-processor
- recoil nerve bridge
- adrenal trigger implant
- shield sync lattice
- threat analysis node

Relic / Exotic

- resonance spine
- phase gland
- echo receptor
- void-hush cortex mesh
- starwake filament

Risk System Idea

Relic implants can be stronger but may build **Resonance Exposure**, causing:

- whispers in logs
- visual distortion events
- special powers
- faction reactions
- corruption or awakening risks later

---

12. Gear Slots

Character Slots

- helmet / hood / visor
- torso armor
- gauntlets
- greaves
- boots
- primary weapon
- secondary weapon
- heavy / utility slot
- relic / focus slot
- implant slots x3
- charm / insignia slot

Ship Slots

- hull
- engine
- reactor
- shield core
- sensor suite
- weapon hardpoints
- utility bay
- cargo bay
- drone bay
- relic containment slot

---

13. Enemy Families

Normal Frontier Threats

- pirates
- corsair raiders
- scav gangs
- rogue militia
- rogue security drones
- void fauna
- contract mercenaries

Mid-Tier Strange Threats

- signal-burned crews
- relic-touched marauders
- hollow drones
- ash pilgrims
- glass cult cells
- phase-spliced beasts

Late Horror Threats

- drowned heralds
- sovereign shards
- cathedral things
- black choir vessels
- null-born leviathans

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14. Zone / Sector Naming Ideas

Hub Names

- Meridian Station
- Crownlight Port
- Hollow Reach
- Driftgate Exchange
- Bastion Ring
- Carrow Spindle

Sector Names

- Ashwake Belt
- Orison Verge
- Cinder Span
- The Hush Expanse
- Nadir Reach
- Vale Meridian
- Glass Orbit
- Black Cauter Sector

Dungeon / Instance Names

- derelict frigate
- sealed observatory
- abandoned relay core
- excavation vault
- cryo ark
- blacksite foundry
- signal shrine
- broken cathedral ship

---

15. Starter Hub — Meridian Station

Core Concept

Meridian Station is the starter hub and primary early-game social/economic center of Void Sovereigns Online. It is a massive converted mining outpost that once served as the premier trade and transit station for its region of space. Decades ago, Meridian thrived because it sat near reliable Void Relays and was a critical transfer point for freight, passengers, survey teams, military contracts, and deep-sector expeditions.

That era is over.

A series of relay failures and route collapses gradually cut Meridian off from the most profitable corridors. What was once a gleaming regional gateway has become a worn-down frontier outpost full of budget traffic, stranded workers, scavengers, drifters, smugglers, debt-runners, contract crews, and people who cannot afford to leave. It is still enormous, still important, and still busy — but now it feels tired, patched over, and one bad year away from slipping even further.

Station Fantasy

- old prestige, current decline

- blue-collar frontier life
- massive industrial bones beneath commercial retrofits
- practical NASA-punk machinery with stylish 90s anime character energy
- low-rent survival layered over the remains of former grandeur
- a place where fortunes can still start, even if empires no longer care

Why Players Start Here

Meridian is ideal as a starting hub because it gives players:

- access to basic jobs and contracts
- a believable mix of legal and illegal opportunity
- cheap docks, cheap rooms, and cheap work
- many factions operating in the same overcrowded place
- constant traffic from damaged routes, stranded crews, and salvage operations
- a natural place for rumors, relics, black markets, and missing-person jobs

Early-Game Core Goal: the player starts with access to a low-end ship that is good enough for local contracts, short-range travel, and survival work around Meridian, but not good enough to safely reach an active Void Relay. The first major progression objective is to earn enough credits, salvage, parts, licenses, and reputation to acquire a better ship capable of making the trip to a functioning relay and opening the wider game world.

Why Meridian Declined

The station's fall came slowly rather than through one disaster.

Key causes:

- several nearby **Void Relays** became unstable, unreliable, or dead
- major shipping lanes rerouted elsewhere
- better-funded hub stations rose closer to intact relay chains
- military and corporate investment dried up
- infrastructure aged faster than it could be fully replaced
- Meridian became a place people used when they had to, not when they had options

Present-Day Identity

Meridian is now:

- a low-rent trade station
- a salvage and contract economy hub
- a choke point for damaged-route traffic
- a haven for freelancers, bounty hunters, haulers, and relic-runners
- a place where respectable institutions and desperate people share the same corridors

It still has prestige in its bones. You can see it in the old concourse architecture, the overbuilt docking ring, the grand transit halls, and the faded insignias from its golden era. But much of that glory is now hidden beneath repair plating, neon patchwork signage, subdivided cargo decks, and improvised housing.

Visual Identity

- gigantic rotating industrial structure built around an old mining spindle
- ore-processing rings converted into docks, markets, machine decks, and hab blocks
- worn utility lighting, hazard striping, repair scaffolds, cargo cranes, exposed conduit
- remnants of old luxury transit architecture mixed with blue-collar grime
- bustling low-rent food stalls, contract boards, used parts kiosks, shrine corners, crew bars, and faction booths
- overall presentation: practical station hardware, but animated with stylish 90s anime silhouettes, coats, jumpsuits, visors, and ship-crew swagger

Districts

The Spine

The oldest central structural column of the station, once built for ore transfer and heavy processing. Now it is packed with machine access, maintenance routes, lift systems, repair tunnels, and old sealed sections.

Gameplay role: industrial jobs, engineering contacts, maintenance missions, hidden routes

Crown Concourse

The old prestige commercial ring. Once elegant, now half-faded but still functioning as the station's most visible public face.

Gameplay role: markets, faction kiosks, civilian shops, transit terminals, starter social hub

Dock Nine Belt

A rough docking district used by independent haulers, salvage crews, and contract ships. Loud, dangerous, busy, and full of opportunity.

Gameplay role: ship services, cargo jobs, smuggling hooks, bounty postings, black-market contacts

The Shallows

Low-rent residential and spillover commercial decks formed from repurposed worker housing, abandoned support corridors, and subdivided hab modules.

Gameplay role: starter housing flavor, local side quests, gang trouble, missing persons, everyday station life

Ash Market

A gray-market bazaar where scavenged goods, questionable relic fragments, hacked components, and expired military stock quietly circulate.

Gameplay role: rare item hooks, illegal jobs, rumor gathering, risky upgrades

Relay Chapel

A district built around an old relay-monitoring and memorial complex. Officially it is part shrine, part signal archive, part civic remembrance space.

Gameplay role: lore, memorial quests, signal anomaly rumors, early subtle cosmic-horror foreshadowing

Core Services

Meridian should contain the player's early core loop services:

- contract board
- ship dock and refuel/resupply services
- fabrication shop
- medbay
- low-tier market vendors
- ship part broker
- bounty registry terminal
- storage and freight locker
- faction liaison kiosks
- bar / crew canteen / rumor hub

Story Function

Meridian Station should anchor the early game as a place where the player is just another working spacer trying to stay solvent. The station teaches the contract loop, introduces factions, establishes ship ownership as central progression, and slowly exposes the player to odd reports connected to the broken relay network.

The player's practical dream in the early game is simple: stop living contract to contract in a barely reliable local craft and earn a ship good enough to break out of Meridian's shrinking orbit. Reaching a functioning Void Relay should feel like the first true threshold moment of the game.

The cosmic threat should first be felt here through:

- strange relay static
- archived distress logs
- rumors of crews vanishing on short routes
- station workers speaking about sealed decks and signal dead zones
- relic fragments circulating through Ash Market
- memorial walls with too many recent names

Tone Keywords

- faded grandeur
- practical survival
- crowded loneliness
- blue-collar sci-fi
- station romance
- rust and neon
- industrial melancholy
- frontier opportunity

Recommended Supporting NPC Types

- exhausted dockmaster
- cheerful junk dealer
- contract dispatcher with military past
- medtech who patches up freelancers for cash
- old relay archivist
- suspicious Synod observer
- Aegis liaison pretending to be unimportant
- bartender who always hears things first
- ship mechanic who can keep anything flying

Starter Hub Summary

Meridian Station is a giant former premier trade and mining outpost now living on damaged-route traffic, salvage, and desperation. It is big enough to feel legendary, worn enough to feel believable, and crowded enough to support contracts, factions, markets, ship progression, and mystery from the very start.

16. Currency and Resource Ideas

Currencies

- Credits
- Fleet Marks
- Synod Seals

- Black Market Scrip
- Relic Tokens

Crafting / Upgrade Resources

- salvage alloy
- polymer weave
- reactor dust
- charge gel
- medfoam compounds
- quantum seals
- relic glass
- null residue
- signal ash

---

16. Folder Structure for the New Project

```
void-sovereigns-online/
  docs/
    game-bible/
      world-overview.md
      style-guide.md
      terminology.md
      factions.md
      classes.md
      races.md
      starships.md
      weapons.md
      implants.md
      enemies.md
      sectors.md
      progression.md
    roadmap/
      milestone-01-vertical-slice.md
      milestone-02-content-pipeline.md
      milestone-03-multiplayer.md
  client/
    public/
    src/
      app/
        routes/
        layout/
```

```
      store/
    game/
      scenes/
      systems/
      entities/
      combat/
      ui/
      assets/
      data/
        factions/
        classes/
        races/
        weapons/
        ammo/
        items/
        implants/
        ships/
        enemies/
        sectors/
        lore/
        quests/
    shared/
      types/
      constants/
      utils/
server/
  src/
    config/
    auth/
    rooms/
    world/
    combat/
    inventory/
    progression/
    economy/
    chat/
    factions/
    events/
    persistence/
    scripts/
shared/
  schema/
  types/
  constants/
```

```
content/
  json/
    factions/
    classes/
    races/
    weapons/
    ammo/
    items/
    implants/
    ships/
    enemies/
    sectors/
    lore/
    quests/
    events/
  localization/
tools/
  content-validation/
  generators/
  migration/
art/
  logos/
  ui/
  concept/
  icons/
audio/
  music/
  sfx/
```

---

17. Strong First-Pass Final Picks

Recommended Launch Hub

Meridian Station

Recommended Starter Sector Names

- Ashwake Belt
- Orison Verge
- Nadir Reach

Recommended Launch Races

- Human
- Aurelans
- Bronti
- Nyxari
- Veyl

Recommended Launch Classes

- Vanguard
- Operator
- Adept
- Ranger
- Bounty Hunter
- Warden

Recommended Tone Keywords

- lonely
- elegant
- frontier
- dangerous
- stylish
- practical
- beautiful
- ancient
- restrained
- uncanny

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18. Direction Locked for Next Pass

- **Overall setting:** NASA-punk practical in-world, with a stylish 90s anime presentation
- **Species design:** mostly humanoid silhouettes
- **Ship ownership:** central progression pillar
- **Psionics/relic powers:** fringe, distrusted, and uncommon
- **Early game structure:** mostly contract-focused, with story woven into jobs, factions, and discoveries

---

19. Starter Sector — Ashwake Belt

Core Concept

Ashwake Belt is the starter sector directly connected to Meridian Station. It consists of old mining asteroids, cracked extraction platforms, abandoned ore-transfer rigs, tethered worker habitats, and half-functional industrial nodes scattered through a dusty debris field. Once, the belt fed Meridian's rise. Now it survives as a low-profit salvage zone, contract site, and danger pocket for beginner crews.

Ashwake is close enough to Meridian for routine traffic, cheap jobs, and emergency returns, which makes it the natural first sector for new players. It introduces the game's core loop: fly out from the station, take contracts, clear threats, salvage materials, and return with enough profit to keep your ship running.

Sector Fantasy

- nearby but hazardous frontier work
- worn industrial asteroid infrastructure
- dead extraction lines and drifting machinery
- beginner salvage and combat jobs
- proof that Meridian's past wealth came from real labor and real extraction
- first hints that some old mining sites shut down for reasons beyond ordinary bankruptcy

Visual Identity

- dark rock bodies laced with old mining cuts and floodlights
- rusted gantries and mag-rail trusses spanning asteroid surfaces
- drifting cargo containers and severed tether lines
- rotating processing rigs with partial power
- faded corporate logos from Meridian's golden age
- damaged maintenance drones moving through dust clouds and spark-lit corridors

Why It Matters

Ashwake Belt teaches players:

- ship launch and return loop
- contract acceptance and completion
- early combat against mechanical enemies
- salvage and crafting resource collection
- dungeon/instance exploration in a practical sci-fi context
- how the frontier survives on the bones of old industry
- how local work feeds into the larger goal of upgrading to a relay-capable ship

Main Threats

- rogue mining robots
- damaged loader frames
- corrupted drilling drones
- defensive turret clusters
- desperate scav crews
- unstable reactor or vent hazards

Why the Robots Went Rogue

Publicly, the answer is simple: deferred maintenance, old automation systems, corrupted firmware, and abandoned sites left running too long.

Unofficially, some black-box logs and sealed maintenance reports hint that a few shutdown incidents involved:

- sensor ghosts
- command loops from dead signal relays
- units following non-human pattern instructions
- miners reporting strange audio from deep shafts before disappearing

These details should stay subtle early on.

Early Dungeons / Instances

1. Shalehook Dig Site

A stripped-down asteroid mine with unstable loader tunnels, broken conveyors, and hostile extraction drones.

Purpose: first simple dungeon
Threats: cutter drones, loader bots, turret nodes
Rewards: salvage alloy, charge gel, low-tier ship parts, basic weapon mods

2. Cinder Jack Processing Node

A half-powered ore refinery platform where automated defense systems still treat all intruders as trespassers.

Purpose: first harder dungeon
Threats: sentry bots, mag-clamp walkers, refinery hazards
Rewards: polymer weave, reactor dust, fabrication parts, uncommon components

3. Lantern Vein Access Shaft

A sealed and partially collapsed drilling facility dug deeper than station records comfortably explain.

Purpose: early mystery dungeon
Threats: rogue mining frames, environmental hazards, strange sensor interference
Rewards: relic-touched scrap, unusual logs, anomaly foreshadowing, rare crafting resources

Sector Subzones

- **Outer Cut:** easy asteroid work sites and salvage paths
- **Breaker Yard:** damaged processing rigs and scrapyard combat spaces
- **Tether Grave:** drifting work platforms and cut hab sections
- **Lantern Vein Cluster:** deeper, more dangerous mining sites with mystery hooks

Rewards and Resources

Primary early resources found here:

- salvage alloy
- polymer weave
- reactor dust
- charge gel
- damaged servos
- mining optics
- hull sealant foam
- broken AI cores

Story Function

Ashwake Belt establishes the ordinary frontier reality of the game. It shows that work is dangerous, equipment is old, and every faction is trying to squeeze profit out of failing infrastructure. It also quietly plants the first layer of mystery through corrupted maintenance logs, vanished miners, and a few machine behaviors that do not fully fit normal malfunction patterns.

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20. Meridian Station — Early NPC Roster

20.1 Tamsin Vale — Contract Dispatcher

Former logistics officer who now manages a large share of low-tier freelance jobs around Meridian.

Role: first major mission giver
Personality: brisk, competent, dry humor, permanently overworked
Function: introduces contracts, teaches players how to build reputation, points them toward Ashwake Belt

20.2 Rook Mendera — Dockmaster of Dock Nine Belt

A hard-edged veteran who knows every kind of pilot, scam, and cargo trick in the district.

Role: ship launch/dock services, local warnings
Personality: skeptical, sharp, secretly protective of new crews who listen
Function: teaches ship procedures, docking, fuel/resupply, basic survival advice

20.3 Ilya Sorn — Ship Mechanic

Keeps starter ships alive with salvaged parts, profanity, and miracles.

Role: repair, upgrade introduction, basic ship progression
Personality: blunt, funny, grease-stained genius
Function: early ship upgrades, repair tutorials, introduces junker-to-keeper progression

20.4 Nera Quill — Ash Market Parts Broker

Dealer in scavenged components, questionable mods, and things that "fell off a freighter."

Role: gray-market vendor
Personality: charming, opportunistic, always three steps ahead
Function: early black-market gear, risky upgrades, rumor hooks, scavenger contacts

20.5 Brother Caldus — Relay Chapel Archivist

Caretaker of old relay memorials, signal logs, and the station’s forgotten names.

Role: lore and memorial quest giver
Personality: gentle, unnervingly observant, speaks like history is alive
Function: introduces old relay lore, missing crews, and the first subtle anomaly threads

20.6 Dr. Sena Marr — Freelance Medtech

Patches up anyone who can pay and a few who cannot.

Role: healing, consumables, field survival guidance
Personality: practical, compassionate, tired of preventable stupidity
Function: med items, healing loop, recovery after dangerous contracts

20.7 Vey Oris — Bounty Registry Liaison

Officially tracks wanted targets, fugitive crews, and local enforcement contracts.

Role: bounty mission giver
Personality: polished, detached, quietly ruthless
Function: introduces target-hunt jobs, criminal factions, and higher-risk combat work

20.8 Lio Vent — Crew Bar Owner

Runs a station bar that doubles as an informal information exchange for freelancers.

Role: rumor hub
Personality: warm until crossed, impossible to surprise
Function: side quests, local gossip, hidden job leads, social worldbuilding

20.9 Agent Serik Dane — Aegis Observer

Official cover identity: "transit risk analyst." Actual role: clearly more than that.

Role: shadowy mid-early quest contact
Personality: controlled, precise, unreadable
Function: introduces classified salvage recoveries, sealed decks, and suspicious relay investigations

20.10 Asha Renn — Frontier Compact Quartermaster

Coordinates supplies and defense aid for struggling local crews and colony traffic.

Role: practical faction representative
Personality: grounded, no-nonsense, community-minded
Function: introduces civic-defense jobs, supply runs, militia support, and local reputation building

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21. Early Contract Categories

21.1 Scrap Recovery

Retrieve usable parts, broken robotics, processed ore stock, or lost cargo from old work sites.

Gameplay focus: exploration, light combat, salvage economy
Typical location: Ashwake Belt dig sites and processing platforms

21.2 Robot Suppression

Clear rogue mining robots, defensive drones, or malfunctioning security units from abandoned or semi-active facilities.

Gameplay focus: core early combat loop
Typical location: mines, refineries, old maintenance corridors

21.3 Equipment Retrieval

Recover a damaged toolkit, black box, power regulator, ship part, or relay component from a hostile site.

Gameplay focus: objective-based dungeon runs
Typical location: derelicts and sealed industrial nodes

21.4 Survey and Scan Jobs

Map asteroid pockets, verify signal disturbances, inspect relays, or scan unstable industrial zones.

Gameplay focus: travel, exploration, subtle mystery introduction
Typical location: outer debris routes, relay-monitoring sites, sealed shafts

21.5 Bounty Contracts

Track fugitives, deserters, scavenger leaders, smugglers, or station-wanted raiders.

Gameplay focus: target hunting, combat escalation, criminal worldbuilding
Typical location: dock districts, belt hideouts, wreck clusters

21.6 Escort and Freight Runs

Accompany a hauler, protect a shuttle, move scarce supplies, or deliver time-sensitive components.

Gameplay focus: route risk, defense, station-to-sector loop
Typical location: Meridian to nearby sector lanes

21.7 Missing Crew Investigations

Search for miners, surveyors, repair teams, or independent pilots who failed to return.

Gameplay focus: mystery, environmental storytelling, higher narrative weight
Typical location: deep belt work sites, collapsed access shafts, old hab modules

21.8 Station Trouble Jobs

Handle gang problems, repair failures, thefts, local disputes, and civic maintenance issues inside Meridian.

Gameplay focus: hub life, side quests, low-travel variety
Typical location: The Shallows, Dock Nine Belt, Crown Concourse

Contract Structure Philosophy

Early contracts should feel like real frontier work first:

- practical
- dangerous
- underpaid
- immediate

But they should all also feed the first major player ambition:

- earn enough to stop renting survival
- improve or replace the starter ship
- secure better components
- qualify for longer-range work
- eventually reach an active Void Relay

Layered beneath that should be a gradually growing pattern:

- too many broken logs
- too many vanished workers
- too many machine systems acting strangely near damaged relays
- too many people insisting it is all coincidence

Recommended Early Contract Mix

The opening hours should emphasize:

- Scrap Recovery
- Robot Suppression
- Equipment Retrieval
- a few Station Trouble Jobs
- one or two Missing Crew Investigations with quiet anomaly undertones

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22. Early Core Progression Goal

The First Big Dream

The early game should revolve around one clear practical objective:

Buy, win, rebuild, or otherwise secure a better ship that can safely reach a functioning Void Relay.

This goal gives structure to the contract loop and makes progression feel grounded. The player is not chasing abstract destiny at first — they are trying to escape the trap of local-only survival and earn passage into the wider frontier.

Starting Ship Situation

The player begins with a ship that is:

- old
- cheap
- barely spaceworthy
- good enough for local sector work
- not trusted for deep-route relay travel

Possible starter ship framing:

- inherited wreck
- debt-anchored lease ship
- repo-surplus contractor skiff
- ex-industrial utility craft patched for civilian use

What the Better Ship Represents

A relay-capable ship means:

- freedom of movement
- access to better-paying sectors
- access to larger faction work
- a real stake in the wider galaxy
- the beginning of the game's next chapter

What the Player Needs to Get There

To reach this milestone, the player may need a combination of:

- credits
- salvage materials
- upgraded drive components

- a route permit or relay clearance
- faction reputation
- black-market parts or legal certification

Narrative Importance

This objective should define the emotional arc of the early game:

- at first, the player is trapped in Meridian's local economy
- then they learn how the station survives on scraps and failing routes
- then they build enough resources and trust to attempt something bigger
- finally, reaching the Void Relay becomes the first major transition from local drifter to true frontier operator

Design Value

This goal works because it ties together:

- ship progression
- contracts
- economy
- faction reputation
- exploration
- story escalation

It is concrete, understandable, and motivating.

23. Suggested Next Docs

Next, build these in order:

1. `WORLD_OVERVIEW.md`
2. `FACTIONS.md`
3. `STARTER_SECTOR.md`
4. `EARLY_GAME_LOOP.md`
5. `STARSHIP_PROGRESSION.md`
6. `CLASSES.md`
7. `RACES.md`
8. `WEAPONS_AND_IMPLANTS.md`